of packets of information are *transacted* between humans and machines using the Internet, and blockchain technology is forcing us to rethink the costs, security, and ownership of these transactions.

Blockchain technology came from Bitcoin. In other words, Bitcoin is the mother of blockchain technology. Bitcoin, with a capital *B*, is a platform that carries upon it programmable money, known as bitcoin with a lowercase *b*. The technological foundation to this platform is a distributed and digital ledger referred to as a blockchain. In January 2009, when Bitcoin was first released, it embodied the first working implementation of a blockchain the world had seen.

Since then, people have downloaded the open-source software that is Bitcoin, studied its blockchain, and released different blockchains that go far beyond Bitcoin. Blockchain technology can now be thought of as a general purpose technology, on par with that of the steam engine, electricity, and machine learning.

To quote a May 2016 article in *Harvard Business Review* by Don and Alex Tapscott: "The technology most likely to change the next decade of business is not the social web, big data, the cloud, robotics, or even artificial intelligence. It's the blockchain, the technology behind digital currencies like bitcoin."[7]

Incumbents are sensing the inherent creative destruction, especially within the financial services sector, understanding that winners will grow new markets and feast off the disintermediated. Many startups are eyeing these middlemen